

Customer Success English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders

Focus: A customer success English curriculum for onboarding, adoption, health scoring, escalations, QBRs, renewals, churn risk, difficult customers, product feedback, and expansion conversations.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
onboarding	In customer success, onboarding is a capability or authorization process used to prepare, verify, or document that a person can perform a role. Use it when teams need to set realistic timelines and responsibilities after the sale.	clarify onboarding; document onboarding	Contrast: onboarding should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify onboarding and the evidence that supports it.
go-live	In customer success, go-live is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to set realistic timelines and responsibilities after the sale.	clarify go-live; document go-live	Contrast: go-live should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify go-live and the evidence that supports it.
implementation	In customer success, implementation is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to set realistic timelines and responsibilities after the sale.	clarify implementation; document implementation	Contrast: implementation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify implementation and the evidence that supports it.
customer owner	In customer success, customer owner is a stakeholder category whose needs, eligibility, experience, or obligations affect the decision. Use it when teams need to set realistic timelines and responsibilities after the sale.	clarify customer owner; document customer owner	Contrast: customer owner should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify customer owner and the evidence that supports it.

Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
adoption	In customer success, adoption is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss account health without reducing it to one number.	clarify adoption; document adoption	Contrast: adoption should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify adoption and the evidence that supports it.
health score	In customer success, health score is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to discuss account health without reducing it to one number.	track health score; explain a change in health score	Contrast: health score measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track health score by segment and explain what changed.
stakeholder engagement	In customer success, stakeholder engagement is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss account health without reducing it to one number.	clarify stakeholder engagement; document stakeholder engagement	Contrast: stakeholder engagement should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify stakeholder engagement and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
usage	In customer success, usage is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss account health without reducing it to one number.	clarify usage; document usage	Contrast: usage should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify usage and the evidence that supports it.

Support Escalations and Incident Communication

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
escalation	Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.	clarify escalation; document escalation	Contrast: escalation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify escalation and the evidence that supports it.
severity	In customer success, severity is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coordinate urgent customer issues across support and product.	clarify severity; document severity	Contrast: severity should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify severity and the evidence that supports it.
workaround	In customer success, workaround is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to coordinate urgent customer issues across support and product.	clarify workaround; document workaround	Contrast: workaround should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify workaround and the evidence that supports it.
SLA	Service-level agreement defining expected service performance or response commitments.	clarify SLA; document SLA	Contrast: SLA should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify SLA and the evidence that supports it.

QBRs and Business Outcomes

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
QBR	In customer success, QBR is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to run business reviews that connect product use to value.	clarify QBR; document QBR	Contrast: QBR should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify QBR and the evidence that supports it.
business outcome	In customer success, business outcome is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to run business reviews that connect product use to value.	clarify business outcome; document business outcome	Contrast: business outcome should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify business outcome and the evidence that supports it.
ROI	In customer success, ROI is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to run business reviews that connect product use to value.	clarify ROI; document ROI	Contrast: ROI should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify ROI and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
executive sponsor	In customer success, executive sponsor is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to run business reviews that connect product use to value.	clarify executive sponsor; document executive sponsor	Contrast: executive sponsor should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify executive sponsor and the evidence that supports it.

Renewals and Churn Risk

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
renewal	In customer success, renewal is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to talk about renewal risk early and specifically.	clarify renewal; document renewal	Contrast: renewal should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify renewal and the evidence that supports it.
churn risk	In customer success, churn risk is a condition or event that can create harm, loss, noncompliance, delay, or unacceptable performance. Use it when teams need to talk about renewal risk early and specifically.	assess churn risk; mitigate churn risk	Contrast: churn risk identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess churn risk, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.
commercial term	In customer success, commercial term is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to talk about renewal risk early and specifically.	clarify commercial term; document commercial term	Contrast: commercial term should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify commercial term and the evidence that supports it.
value gap	In customer success, value gap is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to talk about renewal risk early and specifically.	clarify value gap; document value gap	Contrast: value gap should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify value gap and the evidence that supports it.

Expansion and Upsell Ethics

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
upsell	In customer success, upsell is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to recommend expansion only when value is credible.	clarify upsell; document upsell	Contrast: upsell should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify upsell and the evidence that supports it.
expansion	In customer success, expansion is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to recommend expansion only when value is credible.	clarify expansion; document expansion	Contrast: expansion should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify expansion and the evidence that supports it.
use case	In customer success, use case is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to recommend expansion only when value is credible.	clarify use case; document use case	Contrast: use case should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify use case and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
readiness	In customer success, readiness is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to recommend expansion only when value is credible.	clarify readiness; document readiness	Contrast: readiness should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify readiness and the evidence that supports it.

Product Feedback and Feature Requests

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
feature request	In customer success, feature request is a formal intake or routing mechanism that starts work, seeks a decision, or transfers responsibility. Use it when teams need to translate customer requests into product evidence.	clarify feature request; document feature request	Contrast: feature request should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify feature request and the evidence that supports it.
roadmap	In customer success, roadmap is a structured course of action that assigns priorities, sequencing, assumptions, and responsible roles. Use it when teams need to translate customer requests into product evidence.	align on the roadmap; revise the roadmap	Contrast: roadmap sets an intended course of action; it is not proof that the work is feasible or approved. Example: Before we revise the roadmap, we need to test the dependency and resource assumptions.
workaround	In customer success, workaround is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to translate customer requests into product evidence.	clarify workaround; document workaround	Contrast: workaround should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify workaround and the evidence that supports it.
product feedback	In customer success, product feedback is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to translate customer requests into product evidence.	clarify product feedback; document product feedback	Contrast: product feedback should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify product feedback and the evidence that supports it.

Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
boundary	In customer success, boundary is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to stay calm when customers are angry or unrealistic.	clarify boundary; document boundary	Contrast: boundary should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify boundary and the evidence that supports it.
executive escalation	In customer success, executive escalation is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to stay calm when customers are angry or unrealistic.	clarify executive escalation; document executive escalation	Contrast: executive escalation should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify executive escalation and the evidence that supports it.
commitment	In customer success, commitment is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to stay calm when customers are angry or unrealistic.	clarify commitment; document commitment	Contrast: commitment should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify commitment and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
expectation setting	In customer success, expectation setting is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to stay calm when customers are angry or unrealistic.	clarify expectation setting; document expectation setting	Contrast: expectation setting should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify expectation setting and the evidence that supports it.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Onboarding and Implementation Expectations	Before we commit, I want to confirm onboarding, go-live, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, data readiness, customer owner, training, and risk need alignment., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Adoption Metrics and Health Scores	Before we commit, I want to confirm adoption, health score, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If depth of adoption, business outcomes, sponsor engagement, and support trends matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Support Escalations and Incident Communication	Before we commit, I want to confirm escalation, severity, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If severity, workaround, reproduction, priority, and communication cadence need agreement., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
QBRs and Business Outcomes	Before we commit, I want to confirm QBR, business outcome, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If customer goals, outcomes, risks, recommendations, and executive asks should guide the story., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Renewals and Churn Risk	Before we commit, I want to confirm renewal, churn risk, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If adoption gaps, unresolved issues, executive alignment, and commercial terms need a recovery plan., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Expansion and Upsell Ethics	Before we commit, I want to confirm upsell, expansion, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If readiness, value proof, use case, and customer trust must be considered., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Product Feedback and Feature Requests	Before we commit, I want to confirm feature request, roadmap, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If segment fit, revenue impact, workaround, frequency, and roadmap tradeoff need assessment., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting	Before we commit, I want to confirm boundary, executive escalation, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If priority, feasibility, contractual commitments, and respectful boundaries need clear communication., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
onboarding vs customer owner	In onboarding and implementation expectations, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
adoption vs usage	In adoption metrics and health scores, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
escalation vs SLA	In support escalations and incident communication, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
QBR vs executive sponsor	In qbrs and business outcomes, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
renewal vs value gap	In renewals and churn risk, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
upsell vs readiness	In expansion and upsell ethics, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
feature request vs product feedback	In product feedback and feature requests, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
boundary vs expectation setting	In difficult customers and boundary setting, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.